The Future of AI: Opportunities, Risks, and Practical Impact

A comprehensive exploration of artificial intelligence's transformative power, potential dangers, and real-world applications shaping tomorrow.

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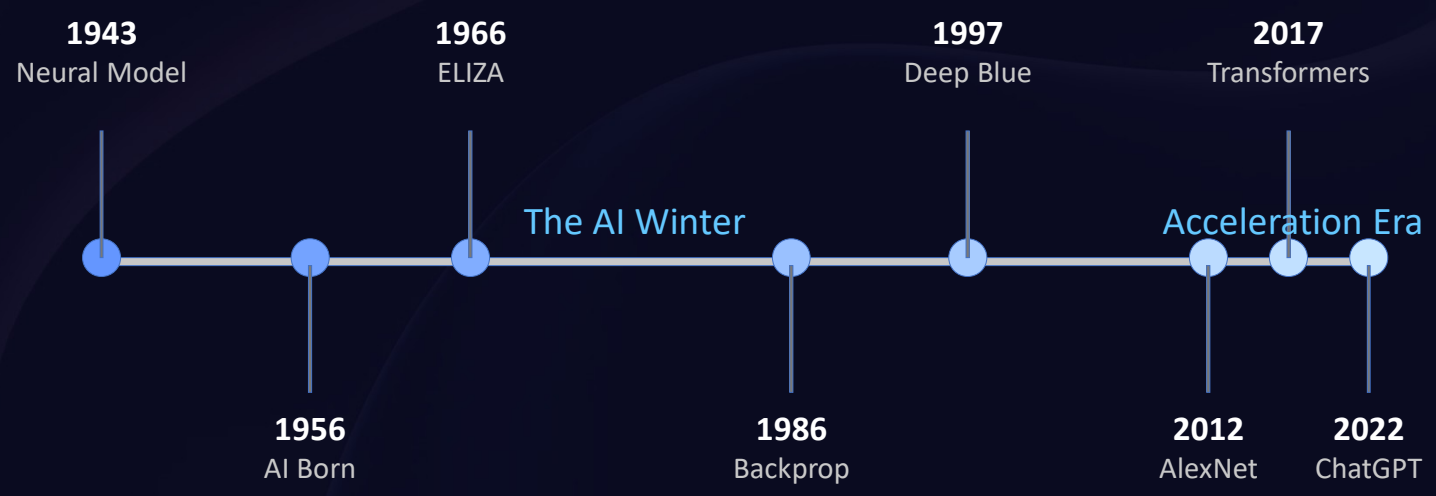
Understanding AI Today and Tomorrow

Artificial intelligence is no longer science fiction—it's the driving force behind innovation across every industry. Understanding its foundations, capabilities, and trajectory is essential for navigating our AI-powered future.

• We went from decades of slow progress to rapid breakthroughs in just 10–15 years.
•"That acceleration is why AI is now a strategic priority for every organization."

Evolution of Artificial Intelligence



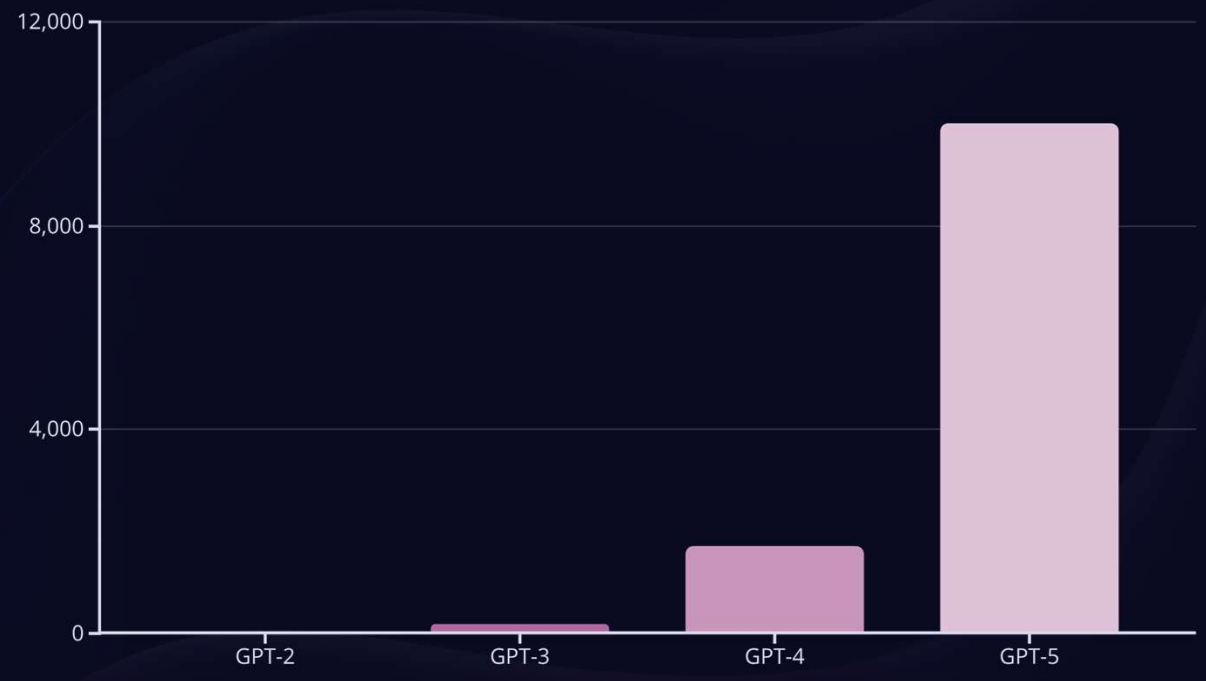
- What's most important here isn't just the milestones – it's the pace.
- We went from decades of slow progress to rapid breakthroughs in just 10-15 years.
- That acceleration is why AI is now a strategic priority for every organization.

AI's Rapid Capability Growth

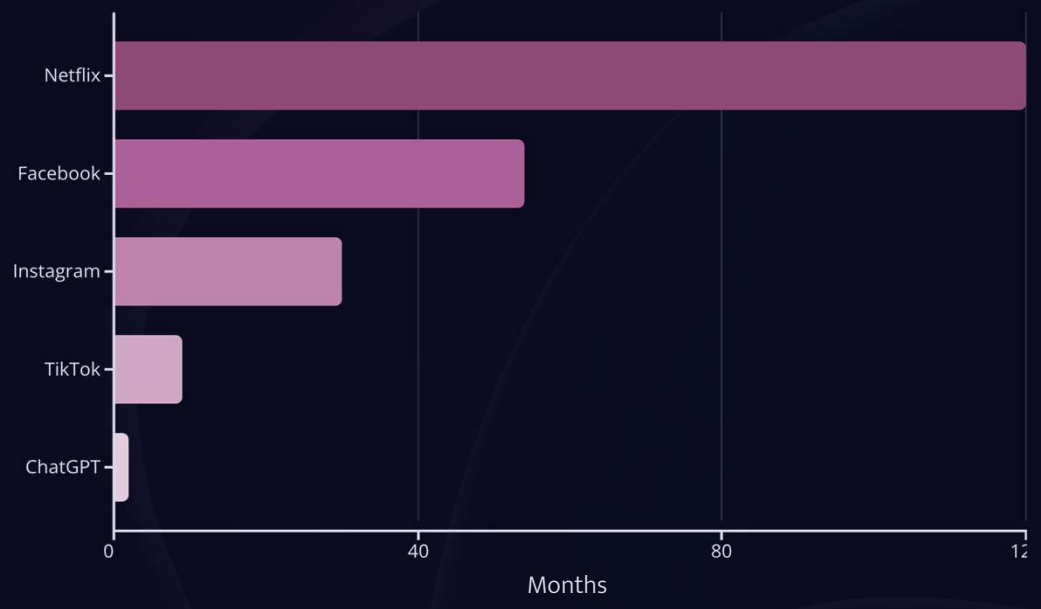
Exponential Advancement

Modern AI models like GPT-5 contain trillions of parameters, enabling them to perform complex reasoning, creative generation, and multi-modal understanding across text, images, audio, and video simultaneously.

These systems now tackle tasks once thought exclusive to human intelligence: writing sophisticated code, conducting scientific research, creating original art, and engaging in nuanced conversation.



Unprecedented Adoption: ChatGPT's Meteoric Rise



User adoption rates are critical indicators of a technology's immediate impact and appeal. Historically, social media and entertainment platforms have set benchmarks for rapid growth.

However, ChatGPT shattered these records, reaching an astounding **100 million** users in just two months. This unparalleled speed highlighted the massive public appetite and immediate utility perceived in advanced generative AI.

This rapid embrace underscores a pivotal moment: AI is no longer a niche technology but a mainstream phenomenon quickly integrating into daily life.

Traditional AI vs. Generative AI

While both fall under the AI umbrella, Traditional AI and Generative AI operate on fundamentally different principles, leading to distinct capabilities and applications.

Traditional AI VS Generative AI

Traditional AI	Features	Generative AI
Analyzes data, performs specific tasks	Focus	Creates new data (text, images, music)
Explicit rules and algorithms	Learning Approach	Data-driven learning (neural networks)
Solutions or classifications	Output	Entirely new content
Master chef following a recipe	Analogy	Innovative chef creating new dishes
Accuracy, efficiency, reasoning	Best suited for	Creativity, content generation, exploring possibilities

AI is Everywhere

From smart homes that anticipate your needs to intelligent cities optimizing traffic and energy, artificial intelligence has become integral to most systems.

Real-World Examples: AI in Your Daily Life

Artificial intelligence often operates behind the scenes, seamlessly enhancing our daily routines without us even realizing it. From personalized recommendations to efficient navigation, AI is an integral part of modern living.

Smart Assistants

Siri, Alexa, and Google Assistant help manage schedules, answer questions, and control smart home devices with voice commands.

Email Spam Filters

Advanced AI algorithms protect your inbox by identifying and filtering out unwanted spam and malicious emails.

Smart Photo Organization

AI in photo apps automatically tags, sorts, and enhances your pictures, making it easy to relive memories.

Personalized Entertainment

Netflix and Spotify leverage AI to recommend movies, shows, and music tailored to your unique preferences.

Optimized Navigation

Navigation apps use real-time AI analysis of traffic data to suggest the fastest routes and avoid congestion.

Online Shopping Suggestions

E-commerce platforms use AI to analyze your browsing and purchase history, offering personalized product recommendations.

EDUCATION & CREATIVITY

AI in Education and Creativity

Adaptive Learning Platforms

AI systems personalize education by analyzing student performance and adjusting content difficulty, pacing, and teaching methods to match individual learning styles and needs.

Creative Co-Creation

AI becomes a creative partner, co-creating music compositions, visual art, and literature while expanding human creative horizons rather than replacing artistic vision.

Professional Design Tools

Architects, filmmakers, and designers leverage AI-assisted tools to prototype faster, explore more possibilities, and bring ambitious visions to life with unprecedented efficiency.

AI Is Already Inside Your Organization!

- Embedded in Microsoft, CRM, accounting platforms
- Employees experimenting independently
- Vendors auto-enabling AI features
- Governance is now a financial issue

CFOs must take action!

Where Mid-Market CFOs Gain Immediate Value

- Board reporting and variance analysis
- Scenario modeling and improved forecasting accuracy
- Automated account reconciliations
- Narrative reporting for board decks
- Faster reporting cycles
- Contract summarization
- Policy drafting
- Real-time fraud & anomaly detection
- AI-driven cyber tools

AI is a margin lever – NOT an IT project!

Mini Case Study: $85M Manufacturing Company

- 5-person finance team
- Month-end close: 12 days
- AI-assisted variance & reporting automation
- Close reduced to 9 days (25% faster)
- ~$120K annual productivity value unlocked

Case Study: 300 employee company providing customer support to e-commerce brands

Before AI:

All customer inquiries handled by human agents
Tickets came in via email and chat
Agents manually categorized and responded

Problems:

⏳ Slow response times (12–24 hours)
💸 High labor costs (needed large support team)
😤 Inconsistent answers between agents
📈 Hard to scale during busy seasons

Case Study: 300 employee company providing customer support to e-commerce brands

After AI:

AI chatbot for first-line support
AI ticket classification + routing
Suggested replies for human agents

New Workflow:

AI answers simple questions instantly (order status, returns)
Complex issues get routed to humans
Agents use AI-suggested responses to reply faster

Case Study continued

Results:

⚡ Response time: reduced from 12–24 hrs. → under 2 minutes (for 60% of tickets)
💰 Support costs: down ~30%
📉 Ticket volume for humans: reduced by ~50%
😊 Customer satisfaction: increased due to faster replies

Why it Worked:

Focused on high-volume, repetitive tasks
Didn’t replace humans — augmented them
Clear ROI: faster service + lower costs

AI handled the repetitive questions, so humans could focus on the complicated ones.

The Competitive Reality

- AI compresses cost structures
- AI accelerates decision cycles
- AI reshapes expectations
- Deliberate adopters will outperform

How CFOs Should Evaluate AI Tools

- Does it improve margin or productivity?
- Does it reduce financial or compliance risk?
- Is governance and auditability built in?
- Can ROI be measured within 6–12 months?

Selected AI Tools

Finance & Accounting Automation Tools

- BlackLine / FloQast – Close automation
- Tipalti / Bill.com – AP automation
- Sage Intacct (AI GL insights)
- UiPath – Process automation

Forecasting & Scenario Planning Platforms

- Microsoft Power BI + AI Insights
- Workday Adaptive Planning
- Vena Solutions (Excel-centric FP&A)
- Anaplan (connected planning)

Contract & Vendor Risk AI

- Ironclad / ContractPodAI
- Icertis / Conga
- Lexion / Evisort
- AI-powered contract summarization tools

Business Intelligence & Analytics

- Tableau + AI insights
- Qlik Sense
- Sisense Fusion
- Power BI with Copilot

Fraud Detection & Cybersecurity AI

- SAS Fraud Management / Fraud.net
- Microsoft Defender XDR
- CrowdStrike Falcon
- Darktrace

AI Governance & Data Protection Tools

- Microsoft Purview + DLP
- Google Security Center
- CASB (Cloud Access Security Broker)
- Audit logging & monitoring platforms

Enterprise AI Assistants

- Microsoft Copilot for 365
- ChatGPT Business / Enterprise
- Google Gemini for Workspace
- Claude Enterprise
- Hatz (allows secure access to multiple tools)

Risks and Challenges of AI

While AI offers tremendous benefits, it also presents serious risks that require careful management. Understanding these challenges is crucial for developing safe, beneficial AI systems.

INTERNATIONAL COOPERATION

Global Collaboration on AI Safety

United for Safety

Over 30 countries and international organizations collaborate on AI risk research, sharing findings and coordinating approaches to emerging challenges.

The International AI Safety Report 2026 synthesizes cutting-edge research, identifies priority risks, and provides evidence-based policy recommendations for governments worldwide.

Initiatives like the AI Safety Summit, OECD AI Principles, and multilateral research partnerships create frameworks for responsible AI development across borders.

Governing AI for a Safe Future

Effective AI governance requires coordinated global action, robust policy frameworks, and informed public participation to ensure technology serves humanity's best interests.

The Four Risks CFOs Should Govern

- Data leakage
- Shadow AI – employees using AI tools without company approval, oversight or security
- Compliance gaps
- Vendor exposure

CFO Risk Assessment Questions

- Do your employees know which AI tools are approved?
- Are teams restricted from entering sensitive data into public AI tools?
- Is AI-generated financial content always reviewed by a human?
- Have your AI vendors been reviewed for privacy and data usage?
- Can you explain to an auditor where AI is used in finance?

If you answer “no” or “not sure to 2 or more, there is usually enough risk to do a deeper review.

Recommended Adoption Path

- Gain visibility into current AI usage
- Approve secure enterprise AI tools
- Pilot one high-ROI finance use case
- Layer in governance & monitoring

Looking Ahead — The AI Horizon

The next decade will witness transformative advances in AI capabilities. Preparing thoughtfully for this future determines whether AI enhances human flourishing or creates new risks.

Conclusion: Shaping AI for the Common Good

Powerful Tool

AI offers transformative potential to solve problems, improve lives, and expand human capabilities

Collective Responsibility

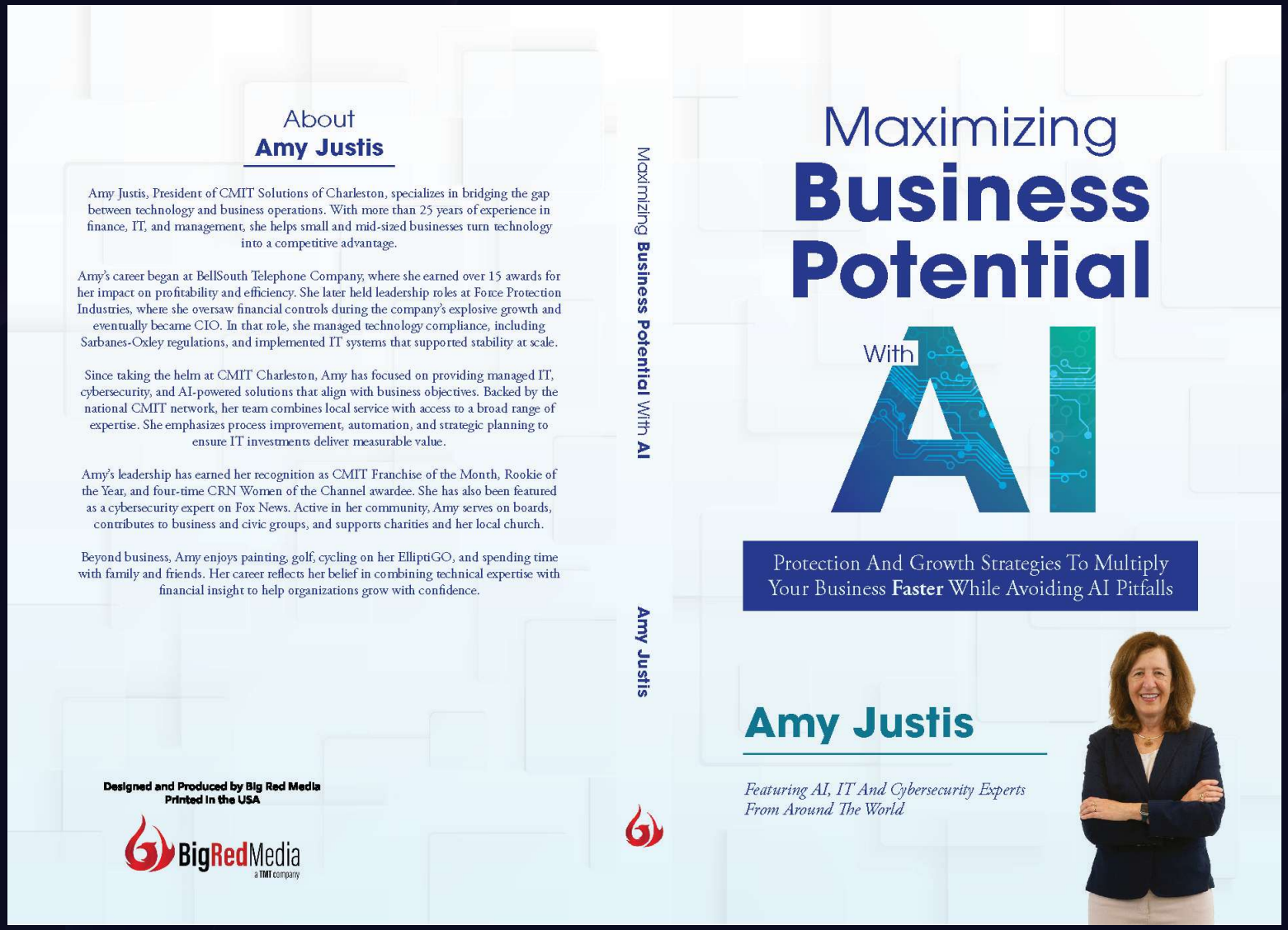
Guiding AI ethically and safely requires participation from everyone—technologists, leaders, and citizens

Our Choice

The future depends on informed users, robust governance, and innovation aligned with human values

Call to Action: Engage with AI developments, educate yourself and others, participate in policy discussions, and help shape AI's impact on our world. The future is not predetermined—it's created by the choices we make today.

Recently launched co-authored book on AI, in collaboration with nineteen other Managed Services Provider business owners.



About
Amy Justis

Amy Justis, President of CMIT Solutions of Charleston, specializes in bridging the gap between technology and business operations. With more than 25 years of experience in finance, IT, and management, she helps small and mid-sized businesses turn technology into a competitive advantage.

Amy's career began at BellSouth Telephone Company, where she earned over 15 awards for her impact on profitability and efficiency. She later held leadership roles at Force Protection Industries, where she oversaw financial controls during the company's explosive growth and eventually became CIO. In that role, she managed technology compliance, including Sarbanes-Oxley regulations, and implemented IT systems that supported stability at scale.

Since taking the helm at CMIT Charleston, Amy has focused on providing managed IT, cybersecurity, and AI-powered solutions that align with business objectives. Backed by the national CMIT network, her team combines local service with access to a broad range of expertise. She emphasizes process improvement, automation, and strategic planning to ensure IT investments deliver measurable value.

Amy's leadership has earned her recognition as CMIT Franchise of the Month, Rookie of the Year, and four-time CRN Women of the Channel awardee. She has also been featured as a cybersecurity expert on Fox News. Active in her community, Amy serves on boards, contributes to business and civic groups, and supports charities and her local church.

Beyond business, Amy enjoys painting, golf, cycling on her EliptiGO, and spending time with family and friends. Her career reflects her belief in combining technical expertise with financial insight to help organizations grow with confidence.

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Maximizing **Business Potential** With **AI**

Amy Justis

Maximizing Business Potential With AI

Protection And Growth Strategies To Multiply Your Business **Faster** While Avoiding AI Pitfalls

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Featuring AI, IT And Cybersecurity Experts From Around The World

Thank You